

Strait of Hormuz and Gulf Route not viable, reopening estimated 6 months

The 2026 Iran war, launched by US–Israeli strikes on 28 February, has stalled in Pakistan-mediated peace talks and despite Trump’s ceasefire extension this week remains in a tense operational standoff with no foreseeable negotiations and the Strait of Hormuz under a dual US–Iran blockade.

- The Strait of Hormuz remains blocked and passage to and from Ras Laffan is not currently possible for a French-flagged LNG tanker.
- The **route is currently not viable** and reopening of passage for operation resumption is estimated at 6 months.
- Current overall risk based on threat actor and route segment is therefore: Iran-linked (HIGH); Houthi-linked (MEDIUM) and Others in Latter Passage (LOW).

Iran-Linked: HIGH

Ras Laffan Port

Intent: Medium | Capability: High

- Loading is technically possible but high-risk. The port remains a strategic Iranian target and has been struck by ballistic missiles, with debris damaging vessels not directly targeted. LNG production is halted, making cargo availability uncertain, though limited tanker movement continues. A French-flagged LNG carrier called within the last 24 hours and is currently anchored. The main constraint is safe entry and exit.

Persian Gulf

Intent: Medium | Capability: Medium

- Vessels unable to cross Hormuz are effectively trapped, and intentional targeting is increasing. A tanker was hit in the Gulf on 1 April, sustaining above-waterline hull damage. For an LNG carrier, such damage may not breach cargo containment but can still cause structural damage.

Strait of Hormuz

Intent: High | Capability: High

- Currently a **no-go zone for the LNG Squirtle**. A US–Iran double blockade has effectively closed the Strait; previously approved flag access has narrowed, and French-flagged vessels are not permitted. On 18 April, a French-flagged containership attempting passage was hit with warning shots and Iranian forces have detained other cargo ships. Iranian sea mines add high-consequence accidental risk.

Port of Fujairah

Intent: Medium | Capability: Medium

- Functioning and theoretically able to support refuelling, but was attacked in March and remains exposed to GPS spoofing, jamming, and renewed strikes. Practical viability depends on safe Hormuz transit, which remains the primary blocker.

Gulf of Oman

Intent: Medium | Capability: High

- Risk is rising. Once a safer buffer outside Hormuz, it is now a kinetic engagement area with increased Iranian activity and US Navy enforcement. The principal threat to LNG Squirtle is Iranian seizure or interdiction.

Houthi-Linked: MEDIUM

Gulf of Aden

Intent: Low | Capability: Medium

- Current risk is low but volatility is high. Houthi commercial attacks are paused, but the group has entered the Iran war politically and militarily. French-flagged vessels are not explicit primary targets, though Houthi targeting has historically been imprecise and based on outdated shipping data.

Bab el-Mandeb and Red Sea

Intent: Medium | Capability: Medium

- Both remain open but escalation potential is high. Houthis retain the capability to harass vessels with missiles, drones, and small boats, and Houthi/Iranian statements have framed the Strait as a likely next closure point if the war continues or Gulf states join against Iran. A US supercarriers' avoidance of the Suez/Red Sea route is a strong risk signal.

Latter Passage: LOW

Suez Canal, Mediterranean Sea, Strait of Gibraltar, English Channel, Denmark Strait

- Low risk overall, though transit will pass through a heavily militarised Eastern Mediterranean which now has three US carrier strike groups and an elevated French and UK naval presence.

Baltic Sea, Inkoo LNG Terminal

- Main concern is GPS spoofing. NATO and Russian naval/air activity has been elevated since the 2022 Ukraine war but reflects the current baseline rather than imminent escalation.

Looking Ahead

- Optimistic estimates put Strait of Hormuz reopening at August; realistic timeline is closer to 6 months.

What to watch

- Houthi re-engagement in the Red Sea, Bab el-Mandeb, or Gulf of Aden which could elevate Section 2 risks and prolong the conflict.
- US-Iran negotiations which could shorten or extend the closure timeline based on success.

Student's Note: Sources available upon request. AI used to improve phrasing and correct grammar – originally written draft also available upon request.